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When Empowerment Isn't Enough

Empowerment is powerful, but leadership cannot become abdication.

Before you empower, assess the team

Giving people room to make decisions can bring out their best. But greater freedom does not automatically give them the skills, experience or judgment the business needs.

During my years of leading businesses, I learned that building the right team and empowering it are inseparable responsibilities. Before giving people greater responsibility, leaders must assess whether the team has the capabilities to succeed—and whether there is time to develop those that are missing.

In one of my assignments, I inherited a loss-making business. Within the first few weeks, it became clear that the leadership team would have to be substantially reshaped. The existing team members were enthusiastic and hardworking, but some of the capabilities required to turn the business around were simply not present. The learning curve would have been too long and the challenge too urgent.

We therefore brought in several highly qualified and experienced leaders from outside the organization. That was not an easy decision, but it gave us the capabilities needed to begin the journey back to profitability.

Empowerment is important—but it cannot compensate for significant gaps in experience, judgement or capability. Before leaders can empower effectively, they must make sure they have built a team capable of carrying that responsibility.

The discipline of holding back

Much has been written about the value of empowerment. It can lead to faster decisions, stronger engagement and better performance. People who are given the trust, tools and autonomy to act can solve problems earlier, build confidence and contribute more meaningfully to the success of the business.

Yet genuine empowerment requires discipline from the leader as well as capability from the team.

I remember a conversation with the CEO of a large international company. He told me that, during leadership-team meetings, he had trained himself not to intervene too quickly when team members were debating a topic or issue.

Given his experience, he often felt that he already knew where the discussion should lead. But rather than immediately offering his own answer, he allowed the team to work through the issue. Frequently, they reached the same conclusion he had already formed. Sometimes, however, they produced a better solution—one he had not considered himself.

His restraint was not passivity. It was a deliberate leadership choice: creating room for others to think, challenge one another and take ownership of the outcome.

Leaders who provide the answer too quickly may get to a decision faster, but they can unintentionally teach their teams to wait for them. Over time, the leader becomes the bottleneck and empowerment becomes little more than a stated intention.

When the leader must decide

There were also occasions when the CEO's team could not reach an agreement. At that point, he stepped in and made the decision.

Strong leaders can empower extensively, precisely because they are willing to accept responsibility when a decision ultimately has to be made. They know when to hold back—but also when to step forward.

Consensus can be a powerful way to build commitment. I worked in a company where we consistently aimed to reach decisions together. Everyone around the table was encouraged to express a view and challenge the proposed direction. But once the discussion was over and the decision had been made, we were expected to leave the room speaking with one voice—even if some of us would personally have preferred a slightly different outcome.

That approach worked because consensus did not mean that every person had to get exactly what they wanted. Nor did it mean postponing uncomfortable decisions until everyone felt completely satisfied.

The pursuit of consensus becomes dangerous when it prevents difficult issues from being confronted, delays action or obscures who is ultimately accountable. At some point, continued discussion no longer improves the decision—it merely avoids making one.

Empowerment is not abdication

The best leaders do not choose between empowerment and decisiveness. They combine the two.

They build teams with the capability to succeed. They give those teams genuine room to contribute and decide. They resist the temptation to dominate every discussion simply because they have more experience or positional authority. But when the team becomes stuck, priorities conflict or the consequences of delay become too serious, they make the call—and accept responsibility for it.

Empowerment should never mean leaving a team without direction, avoiding difficult choices or transferring accountability downwards. Leadership remains leadership.

Perhaps the questions worth asking are:

- Have I built a team that is genuinely capable of carrying the responsibility I give it?
- Do I allow enough space for better ideas to emerge?
- And when a decision can no longer wait, am I willing to make it?